



Power and poise: Anahat (centre) teamed up with Sunayna Kuruvilla for the women's doubles event at the 2022 Commonwealth Games. GETTY IMAGES

playing people like those you mentioned at the World Team Championships who've been at the top for so many years. At the World Team Champs, I played Nele Coll. I had a really close match (1-3) with her. It was on the first day of the tournament, and for the next week, I was so exhausted.

That was a huge learning point. If I'm already so tired from just one match, there's a lot to work on. I wasn't really able to perform too well when I played with the other two girls, but after that, in the last few months, I've been working on staying consistent and being able to play at that level for a long period of time, rather than just playing one tough match and then being tired for the rest of the tournament.

What was your mindset heading into the World Championship Qualifiers (Asia) in Kuala Lumpur last month?

The week before that tournament, I was in Prague, training with my coach, Gregory. I told him that I wasn't playing too well. I wasn't

feeling good inside the court. He said it was fine. I was playing with some of the top players. When you're playing with someone so much better than you, you feel you're not playing really well, but he said it would all come together in the tournament.

I was not very confident going into the tournament. I was expected to play Tanvi (Khanna) in the semis and Akanksha in the finals as per the draw, but they both ended up losing earlier. I had the whole situation planned out, but it turned out to be completely different.

It did give me a bit more confidence because (rather than) playing someone you're facing constantly and are very competitive with, it's better to play someone else who's international and you've not really played against a lot.

I was playing well in the first few matches. I won quite easily and the court also suited me. The final wasn't my best game. I was a bit stressed out because you know when you've reached so close to the finish line and you're like, "Am I going to make it or not?" But I'm glad I was able to make it through.

How do you prepare for your matches at the senior level? Does it involve data and video analysis?

I talk to my coach either on the morning of my match or the night before, but I also like to watch my opponent's match by myself and see what I can do from my perspective.

My coach explains her strong and weak points, but also, analysing yourself rather than someone else telling you is always better. So, the night before, I always like to watch my opponent's match. I might be playing differently that week compared to the week before. So, I don't really like to watch too much in advance. I don't do anything too fancy.

Earlier, the Olympics wasn't in the picture but now, the sport will make its Olympic debut at Los Angeles 2028. There is no guarantee whether it will feature in future editions. How did that change your approach towards the sport?

They had been trying to get squash into the Olympics for the last few years but it wasn't happening. I think the timing couldn't have been more perfect for me. It's going to be when I am 20 and hopefully, at that time, I'm at my peak.

The Olympics is the main aim for every athlete. The training has changed completely. We don't really know what the selection criteria is yet